

British and American spellings

BRITISH AND AMERICAN WORDS ARE OFTEN SPELLED USING DIFFERENT ENDINGS.

In British English, the *l* is often doubled before a suffix, but not in American English. Words that end in *-ise*, *-yse*, *-ce*, *-re*, and *-our* in British English may also be spelled differently in American English.

SEE ALSO

◀ 142–143 Prefixes and suffixes

◀ 154–155 Single and double consonant words

English-language spelling was first **standardized** by the English writer **Samuel Johnson** in 1755.

Doubling the letter *l*

Words that are written with a double *l* in British English are often written with only a single *l* in American English. This usually occurs when a suffix, such as *-or*, *-ed*, *-er*, or *-ing*, is added to a word ending in a single *l*.

British English	American English
cancelled	canceled
counsellor	counselor
fuelled	fueled
jeweller	jeweler
marvelled	marveled
modelling	modeling
quarrelled	quarreled
traveller	traveler

Words ending in *-ise* or *-ize* and *-yse* or *-yze*

Most words that end with *-ise* or *-yse* in British English end with *-ize* or *-yze* in American English. However, the *-ize* and *-yze* spellings are also widely used in Britain.

British English	American English
analyse	analyze
criticise	criticize
hypnotise	hypnotize
mobilise	mobilize
modernise	modernize
organise	organize
recognise	recognize
visualise	visualize

Words ending in *-ce* or *-se*

Certain words that end with *-ce* in British English end with *-se* in American English. Depending on the part of speech, some words, such as *practice* and *licence*, are spelled in two different ways in British English, whereas this distinction is ignored in American English.

British English	American English
defence	defense
licence (noun); license (verb)	license (noun and verb)
offence	offense
pretence	pretense
practice (noun); practise (verb)	practice (noun and verb)